The unread agenda: proposals that never reach a decision

Abstract

We follow twelve recorded meetings of one product team over a quarter and ask what happens to a proposal after it is spoken. The record shows that many proposals are acknowledged in the next turn and then never appear again in the conversation.

Keywords: meetings, proposals, agenda, uptake

A proposal that is not taken up within the following two turns rarely returns to the floor. The pattern holds in all four rooms of the corpus, although the rooms differ in size and in who chairs them.